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# Giftedness Stigma, Social Coping, and Measurement in Gifted Education

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## Background: social-emotional context and why social coping matters in gifted education

*Gifted students often develop in social settings that do not reward visible high ability. Because peers, teachers, and common myths can make giftedness socially risky, many gifted students use coping or identity-management strategies to protect belonging and well-being. (6 sources)*

Social coping matters in gifted education because gifted students do not manage ability in a social vacuum. The literature describes a culture in which intellectual ability can carry negative social meanings, while other traits such as athleticism, sociability, and leadership are valued more positively; in that setting, skewed peer and educator views can push gifted students toward defensive or maladaptive coping responses rather than open expression of ability. (Ely, 2010) Gifted students can also face multiple day-to-day risks to social and emotional development, including being out of step with age peers, frustration with inappropriate instructional pace, tension around intensity and ambition, and even pressure to downplay their abilities in order to belong. Myths such as “gifted kids are nerds,” socially awkward, or otherwise abnormal add to this pressure. (Horvat, 2019) Later reviews make the same point at a broader systems level: stigma, overfocus on achievement, peer competition, lack of resources, and reluctance to seek help can increase stress and isolation for gifted learners. (Rostami, 2023)

This is why social coping is treated as a core issue rather than a side topic. Researchers have argued that giftedness can add stress to normal development, and some studies suggest gifted students are more likely to feel socially isolated and less satisfied with social support; one practical response in the literature is to create grouping or clustering conditions that reduce isolation. (Miller et al., 2012) Social strain can come not only from peers but also from adults: teachers may feel threatened, and peers may reject or mock high-ability students, forcing those students to spend extra effort on coping. (Ziegler et al., 2017) Across this work, a common theme is that misconceptions about gifted students remain widespread among teachers, parents, administrators, and students themselves, which is why researchers have stressed the need for counseling, research, and enriched environments that directly challenge those myths. (Gucyeter et al., 2026)

### Evidence

**(Ely, 2010)**

Understanding the Stereotypes Against Gifted Students: A look at the social and emotional struggles of stereotyped students

> *"American culture places a negative image on intellectual ability, and a more positive image on athleticism, sociability, and leadership (Berlin, 2009). Gifted children have the ability to develop a normal, healthy, well-adjusted self concept, however, skewed peer and educator perspectives of the gifted student can lead the gifted student to react with destructive behaviors and coping mechanisms (Cross, 2005)."*

**(Horvat, 2019)**

SOCIOMETRIC STATUS OF GIFTED STUDENTS IN CLASSROOM AND SUBJECT TEACHING IN ELEMENTARY SCHOOL

> *"Gifted students face a range of situations that pose a source of risk to their emotional and social development. Some of these situations are: intellectual and social progress compared to peers, inappropriate teaching pace with regard to their learning and understanding, tensions created by their ambition, energy, intensity of work compared to peers, negation of their abilities for the purpose of belonging to a group of peers. (Robinson, 2008) also highlights some of the myths that gifted children are often labelled with, such as: gifted children are nerds, are clumsy and socially ill, gifted children can choose any profession in the future and be successful, their acceleration destroys life, have poor social relationships in the family, etc."*

**(Rostami, 2023)**

Social Support Networks and Mental Health in Gifted Students

> *"However, several barriers to support were identified, including stigma, lack of resources, overemphasis on achievement, peer competition, and reluctance to seek help. These barriers exacerbate feelings of isolation and stress, impacting the overall well-being of gifted students."*

**(Miller et al., 2012)**

A Pastiche of Outcomes for a Teacher-Student Pair: Experiences within a Reading Cluster Group

> *"While social and emotional development is necessary for all children and adolescents, researchers postulate that giftedness adds to the stress of development (Coleman & Cross, 2001). Research suggests those who are gifted are more likely to feel socially isolated and dissatisfied with social support (Vialle et al., 2007). As such, clustering may be used to curb feelings of isolation and stress experienced by those who are gifted (Cross, 2005)."*

**(Ziegler et al., 2017)**

Exogenous and Endogenous Learning Resources in the Actiotope Model of Giftedness and Its Significance for Gifted Education

> *"Teachers might feel threatened by their gifted students or peers may denounce their gifted peers as nerds, both of which are unpleasant experiences for many gifted students; they must then devise coping strategies and therefore require more resources (Oh et al., 2015)."*

**(Gucyeter et al., 2026)**

Debunking myths about giftedness: development and psychometric validation of the myths about giftedness scale in the Turkish cultural context

> *"Cross [2] highlighted myths common among teachers, parents, gifted students, and administrators, particularly regarding social and emotional development. He stressed the need for research, counseling, and enriched learning environments to challenge these misconceptions."*

# Coleman and Cross stigma-of-giftedness theory

*Coleman and Cross describe giftedness as a socially risky identity, not just a high level of ability. In this view, many gifted students try to control what others know about their ability so they can keep ordinary peer relationships and avoid being treated differently. (3 sources)*

Coleman and Cross's stigma-of-giftedness theory gives a simple social explanation for why gifted students may hide, soften, or carefully manage signs of high ability. The basic idea is that many gifted students want normal peer interactions, expect that being known as gifted will change how others treat them, and therefore manage what they reveal about their ability so they can keep more social freedom. In other words, giftedness can act like a potentially discrediting social marker, and students respond by trying to control its visibility rather than simply expressing ability openly. (Carter et al., 2025)

This framework has been used to explain the "unique social and emotional experiences" of gifted children and adolescents, especially in peer settings, and it directly links those experiences to social coping. Under the theory, coping is not random; it is a response to anticipated difference, jealousy, rejection, or changed expectations from others once high ability becomes visible. (Guthrie, 2022) (Carter et al., 2025)

Later work cited within this tradition suggests that many gifted students are aware of this social risk and often act on that awareness. Interview evidence across countries reports common concern about the visibility of exceptional ability, peer upward social comparison, and the possibility of jealousy or rejection; students described trying to hide their abilities, conform to peer behavior, or use prosocial strategies such as helping others. Those findings fit the stigma model well because they show students actively managing both how able they appear and how socially acceptable they seem. (Carter et al., 2025) (Cross et al., 2019)

A useful implication of the theory is that “giftedness” is not only a label problem but also a visibility problem. Students may try to conceal the formal gifted label, but they may also try to mask the actual behaviors that reveal ability, especially when those behaviors are less obvious and easier to suppress. That distinction helps explain why some students do not openly deny being gifted yet still limit participation, underplay performance, or avoid standing out. (Carter et al., 2025)

### Evidence

**(Carter et al., 2025)**

School Experiences of Gifted Adolescents and Their Peers

> *"This phenomenon, referred to as "the stigma of giftedness," has been explored through Coleman (1985) Stigma of Giftedness Paradigm (SGP). The SGP is built on three basic tenets:"*
>
> *"1. Gifted students desire normal social interactions"*
>
> *".2. When their giftedness becomes known to others, gifted students believe that they will be treated differently"*
>
> *".3. Gifted students tend to manage the information they reveal about their abilities to maintain a great amount of social latitude"*
>
> *".Multiple studies have shown that gifted students are aware of the SGP and frequently manage the information others have about them to achieve more typical social interactions within the school environment (Coleman et al., 2014); J. R. (Cross et al., 2019)T. L. Cross et al. 1995;T. L. Cross and Stewart 1995)"*
>
> *".In line with the SGP, gifted students may engage in efforts to mask their intellectual differences, particularly those that are less overtly visible (T. L. Cross 1997)."*

**(Guthrie, 2022)**

(Re)fractional narrative inquiry: A methodological adaptation for exploring stories

> *"Coleman's (1985) stigma of giftedness is one framework that has helped identify the unique social and emotional experiences and how they navigate peer relationships. Gifted children and adolescents may develop social coping strategies to manage this stigma among their peers (see (Coleman et al., 2014)Coleman et al., 2015;(Cross et al., 1991)"*

**(Cross et al., 2019)**

A Cross-Cultural Study of the Social Experience of Giftedness

> *"The phenomenon of social coping among students with gifts and talents (SWGT) is not well understood. In interviews with elementary-, middle-, and high-school aged SWGT (N = 90; 50% female) from the United States, United Kingdom, South Korea, Ireland, and France, the universality of awareness of visibility of their exceptional abilities, high expectations and pressure to achieve from adults and peers, and peer jealousy and rejection, was confirmed. In all countries, SWGT were concerned about peers' upward social comparison and the effects of their outperformance on peers' feelings. SWGT attempted to hide their abilities or conform to peers' behaviors. Prosocial helping behaviors were found among SWGT in nearly all age groups and a focus on the self was a useful coping strategy to students in all countries except France. Parallels are drawn between these findings and stigma theory."*

## Empirical evidence that stigma and fear of social rejection motivate gifted identity management

*Studies do not just propose that gifted students manage their identities because of stigma; they report students describing jealousy, rejection, pressure, and changed treatment as real social risks. Those risks appear to motivate concrete responses such as hiding ability, acting humbler, and conforming to peer norms. (5 sources)*

Empirical work in this area supports the claim that gifted identity management is often driven by expected or

experienced social costs. In a cross-cultural qualitative study of 90 gifted students from the United States, United Kingdom, South Korea, Ireland, and France, students across countries showed a common awareness that their abilities were visible, that others held high expectations for them, and that peers could respond with jealousy or rejection. They were also concerned about upward social comparison and about how their outperformance might affect peers' feelings; in response, many said they tried to hide their abilities or conform to peer behavior. The authors explicitly link these patterns to stigma theory, which makes this one of the clearest pieces of evidence that fear of social rejection can motivate gifted identity management. (Misir et al., 2026) (Cross et al., 2019)

Other recent summaries point in the same direction. One review notes that reducing the stigma of giftedness matters because that stigma can drive some children to deny or hide their abilities. (Papadopoulos, 2020) Another source reports that gifted students experienced negative reactions such as jealousy from non-gifted peers and, on average, responded by trying to appear humbler. (Thompson et al., 2021) A more recent account likewise states that pressure to adapt to group habits can push gifted children to hide their abilities in order to gain social acceptance. (Putri et al., 2025)

Taken together, these findings support a specific causal reading of social coping: many gifted students are not simply modest by temperament or casual about achievement; they may be strategically lowering visibility because they expect social penalties if their ability stands out. The strongest recurring motives in the evidence are fear of jealousy, fear of rejection, concern about harming peer relationships, and a desire to remain accepted within the group. (Cross et al., 2019) (Papadopoulos, 2020) (Thompson et al., 2021)

## Evidence

**(Misir et al., 2026)**

Gifted but Misunderstood? An Interpretive Systematic Review of Gifted Education Policy, Practice, and Socio-Emotional Experience in England

> *"(Cross et al., 2019) examined the social stigmatization and coping mechanisms of gifted students through cross-cultural qualitative inquiry, providing valuable insights into the socio-emotional dimensions of giftedness."*

**(Cross et al., 2019)**

A Cross-Cultural Study of the Social Experience of Giftedness

> *"The phenomenon of social coping among students with gifts and talents (SWGT) is not well understood. In interviews with elementary-, middle-, and high-school aged SWGT (N = 90; 50% female) from the United States, United Kingdom, South Korea, Ireland, and France, the universality of awareness of visibility of their exceptional abilities, high expectations and pressure to achieve from adults and peers, and peer jealousy and rejection, was confirmed. In all countries, SWGT were concerned about peers' upward social comparison and the effects of their outperformance on peers' feelings. SWGT attempted to hide their abilities or conform to peers' behaviors. Prosocial helping behaviors were found among SWGT in nearly all age groups and a focus on the self was a useful coping strategy to students in all countries except France. Parallels are drawn between these findings and stigma theory."*

**(Papadopoulos, 2020)**

Psychological Framework for Gifted Children's Cognitive and Socio-Emotional Development: A Review of the Research Literature and Implications

> *"Finally, gifted education initiatives should promote all potential domains and interests and reduce the stigma of giftedness (Robins, Coleman, Micko, & Cross, 2015), which drives some of these children to deny or hide their abilities (Silverman, 1998)."*

**(Thompson et al., 2021)**

A Qualitative Comparative Analysis of Gifted Program Models Based on Student Social Interactions

> *"Cross and colleagues found that not only did gifted students experience negative attributes, such as jealousy from non-gifted peers, in relation to being in a gifted program, but on average gifted students attempted to be humbler as a result of this (2019)."*

**(Putri et al., 2025)**

The Role of Peers in the Social-Emotional Development of Gifted Children in Early Childhood Education

> *"the pressure to adapt to group habits often encourages gifted children to hide their abilities to be accepted in social settings."*

# Measured social coping and identity-management strategies in gifted students

*Researchers have measured a recurring set of social coping strategies in gifted students rather than treating coping as a vague idea. Across studies, the most common measured strategies include hiding or denying giftedness, trying to blend in, managing popularity, using humor, helping others, increasing social involvement, and in some cases underachieving or acting less able than one is. (5 sources)*

- **Denying giftedness.** One of the most consistent measured strategies is simple denial or disavowal of being gifted, captured in SCQ items such as "I don't think that I am gifted" or "People think that I am gifted, but they are mistaken." This strategy appears across multiple SCQ factor studies and is described as one of the basic recurring scales. (KONIK, 2023)
- **Concealing actual ability or masking visible difference.** The literature does not only discuss hiding the gifted *label*; it also describes efforts to mask intellectual difference itself, especially when the signs of ability are not highly visible. This can include not answering questions, reducing vocabulary, or otherwise avoiding behaviors that make ability obvious. (Carter et al., 2025) (KONIK, 2023)
- **Conformity and trying to look like everyone else.** A major coping cluster is blending into peer norms by acting, dressing, or responding like other students. SCQ-based work describes this under peer acceptance and popularity/conformity, with example items such as trying to look or act very similar to other students. (KONIK, 2023) Tourreix et al. also summarize "hiding giftedness or conforming to peers' behaviors" as a specific giftedness-related coping pattern. (Tourreix et al., 2023)
- **Managing popularity and minimizing social cost.** Some measured coping is less about direct concealment and more about reducing the impact of giftedness on peer acceptance or focusing on popularity. In SCQ work, this appears as a popularity/conformity factor, including beliefs about whether being gifted hurts social fit. (KONIK, 2023) (Tourreix et al., 2023)
- **Peer acceptance through impression management.** Several behaviors fit a broader impression-management pattern: gifted students manage what others know, soften how able they appear, and try to preserve "normal" interactions. Recent summaries explicitly frame this as information management under the stigma-of-giftedness paradigm. (Carter et al., 2025)
- **Humor.** Humor is a repeatedly named coping strategy. It has been described as a way gifted students seek social acceptance, especially when they feel misunderstood by classmates, and it also appears as a distinct SCQ factor in some studies. (Demir et al., 2021) (KONIK, 2023) (Tourreix et al., 2023)
- **Helping others and prosocial usefulness.** Another measured strategy is using one's ability in socially acceptable ways, especially by helping classmates with schoolwork or explaining material. This appears in SCQ social interaction items and is also summarized in later reviews as a recurring gifted-specific coping strategy. (KONIK, 2023) (Tourreix et al., 2023)
- **High activity involvement and staying socially busy.** Some students cope by keeping active, joining in, and sharing common interests with peers. Reviews describe "engaging in social interactions and a high activity level to keep busy and share common interests" as one of the measured strategy patterns. (Tourreix et al., 2023) The SCQ tradition also identifies activity level or social interaction as recurring factors. (KONIK, 2023)
- **Seeking affiliation with close friends rather than broad visibility.** The humor findings suggest that some coping happens most strongly in safer peer niches: gifted students may use humor more with close friends when they feel less understood by the larger class group. This points to selective affiliation as part of coping, even when the formal scale label is humor or social interaction. (Demir et al., 2021)
- **Deliberate underachievement or acting less competent.** Some studies and summaries describe more

costly forms of coping, including underachieving, missing chances to answer in class, asking inappropriate questions, lying about grades, or making up missing work to seem “tough.” These are important because they show that identity management can affect academic behavior, not just self-presentation. (KONIK, 2023)

- **Class-clown behavior and attention strategies.** Acting like the class clown appears in summaries of the literature as another way to redirect attention away from gifted difference, and Clark’s three-way description also includes seeking attention as one possible response when giftedness is not accepted. (KONIK, 2023) (Demir et al., 2021)
- **Isolation or withdrawal.** Not all coping is social blending; some students respond by pulling back. One summary notes self-isolation from the group as one of the possible responses when intellectual giftedness is not accepted. (Demir et al., 2021)
- **Cross-cultural variation in which strategies are used.** The broad strategy set is fairly stable, but studies report that use varies by gender, culture, and especially school setting. For example, hiding/conformity is described as common in the United States and some European settings, while showing one’s abilities may be more acceptable in South Korea. (Tourreix et al., 2023) Cross-national interview work also found hiding ability, conforming, and helping others across countries, while some coping patterns varied by national context. (Carter et al., 2025) (Cross et al., 2019)
- **What this list adds conceptually.** Taken together, the measured strategies fall into a few clear families: concealment/denial, conformity/impression management, prosocial compensation, humor, activity-based affiliation, and withdrawal or underachievement. That breakdown is useful because it separates concealment of the *gifted label* from concealment of *actual ability*, which the literature treats as related but not identical social moves. (Carter et al., 2025) (KONIK, 2023)

| Paper | Social Coping Strategies | Cultural Context | Stigma And Social Perception | Emotional And Behavioral Engagement | Peer And Teacher Relationships | Non-Cognitive Specificities |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| A Cross-Cultural Study of the Social Experience of Giftedness | Hide abilities, conform to peers, prosocial helping, self-focus strategy. | Universality of visibility awareness, pressure to achieve, peer jealousy across cultures; self-focus varies, not used in France. | Awareness of exceptional abilities, peer jealousy, rejection; hiding abilities, prosocial behaviors, self-focus coping strategy. | Concern about peers' comparisons, hiding abilities, conforming behaviors, except in France. | High expectations, pressure to achieve, peer jealousy, rejection. | Awareness of visibility, high expectations, peer jealousy, prosocial helping behaviors, focus on self. |

## Evidence

**(KONIK, 2023)**

Turkish adaptation of Social Coping Questionnaire for gifted students

*"These studies claim that gifted children try to cope with their "differentness" by underachieving (Janos et al., 1987), missing to*

*respond to questions in class, asking questions that are not appropriate, acting like the class clown, reducing their vocabulary and lying about getting good grades, making up examinations or assignments to seem tough (Cross et al., 1995), and even denying that they are gifted (Buescher, 1985).Some gifted students believe that they are treated differently and seen as different when others notice their giftedness.(Coleman et al., 2014). Cross et al., 1993;(Manaster et al., 1994)(Manor-Bullock et al., 1995).As a result, these children don't necessarily want to be treated differently or differ intellectually from their peers (Swiatek, 2002)"*

*". Swiatek developed the Social Coping Questionnaire in 1995 to evaluate the particular coping mechanisms employed by gifted students.In its original form, the SCQ (Swiatek, 1995) had 35 questions "that address beliefs and activities relating to various social aspects of intellectual giftedness."A component analysis of the scores revealed four social coping mechanisms: Denial of Giftedness, Popularity/Conformity, Peer Acceptance, and Activity Level"*

*". Swiatek's (2001) most recent replication used a 34-item SCQ yielded a six-factor solution almost identical to that found in her previous study (Swiatek, 2001)"*

*". Results yielded five factors that accounted for 42.0% of the variance: Denying Giftedness, Social Interaction, Humor, Focus on Popularity/Conformity, and Peer Acceptance"*

*". The SCQ, a 34-item self-report questionnaire, was created to evaluate the coping strategies employed by gifted kids to deal with the negative stereotypes and social pressures brought on by being recognized as gifted in a school environment"*

*". SCQ measures five coping styles: Denying giftedness subscale consists of 7 items, (eg."I don't think that I am gifted."Or "People think that I am gifted, but they are mistaken."),Social Interaction subscale consists of 6 items, (eg."People come to me for help with their homework."Or "I explain course material to other students when they don't understand it."),Humor subscale consists of 3 items, (eg."I tell a lot of jokes in school."Or "I'm good at making people laugh."),Focus of Popularity subscale consists of 5 items (eg."Other students do not like me any less because I am gifted."Or "I would fit in better at school if I were not gifted.")and Peer Acceptance subscale consists of 4 items (eg."I try to look very similar to other students."Or "I try to act very much like other students act.")Many studies using the SCQ have shown that there are differentiated social coping strategies according to the sample group in which that study was conducted.As a result, different factorial structure emerged in different studies (Swiatek, 1995(Swiatek, ,.2001;;Swiatek & Dorr, 1998;Swiatek & Cross, 2007;. Cross & Swiatek, 2009).These analyses have yielded between four and seven social coping scales.Each study has discovered three basic scales, which are known as the following: denying giftedness, peer acceptance, and social interaction (Swiatek, 2001)."*

**(Carter et al., 2025)**

School Experiences of Gifted Adolescents and Their Peers

*"This phenomenon, referred to as "the stigma of giftedness," has been explored through Coleman (1985) Stigma of Giftedness Paradigm (SGP). The SGP is built on three basic tenets:"*

*"1. Gifted students desire normal social interactions"*

*".2. When their giftedness becomes known to others, gifted students believe that they will be treated differently"*

*".3. Gifted students tend to manage the information they reveal about their abilities to maintain a great amount of social latitude"*

*".Multiple studies have shown that gifted students are aware of the SGP and frequently manage the information others have about them to achieve more typical social interactions within the school environment (Coleman et al., 2014); J. R. (Cross et al., 2019)T. L. Cross et al. 1995;T. L. Cross and Stewart 1995)"*

*".In line with the SGP, gifted students may engage in efforts to mask their intellectual differences, particularly those that are less overtly visible (T. L. Cross 1997)."*

**(Tourreix et al., 2023)**

Non-Cognitive Specificities of Intellectually Gifted Children and Adolescents: A Systematic Review of the Literature

*"One line of research into the social abilities of gifted youth was interested in social coping, and the literature identified evidence of adaptive social coping abilities in intellectually gifted children and adolescents (Lehman and Erdwins 1981). There appear to be coping strategies that are specific to giftedness (Swiatek, 1995)(Swiatek, 2001), such as denying giftedness; reducing the impact of giftedness on peer acceptance; hiding giftedness or conforming to peers' behaviors; denying importance of popularity; using humor; helping others; and engaging in social interactions and a high activity level to keep busy and share common interests. These social coping strategies may vary depending on gender, social contexts, and especially the school environment. Culture also seems to have an impact on the preferential use of certain social coping strategies over others in the case of giftedness (see (Cross et al., 2009). For example, hiding conformity is a social coping strategy widely used by gifted students in the United States and some European countries, whereas this is not the case in South Korea where it is socially valued to show the extent of one's abilities."*

**(Demir et al., 2021)**

Examining the Relationship between the Sense of Humor and the Social Exclusion Perceived by Gifted and Talented Students

*"In research conducted by Ziv and Gadish (1990), it was observed that gifted and talented children take advantage of humor more because of their desire for social acceptance. When qualitative data from the same study were evaluated, it was found that the classmates of gifted and talented students do not understand them. Thus they used humor more when interacting with their close friends"*

*".Clark's (2014) argued that gifted and talented children prefer one of three ways to respond to situations where their intellectual giftedness is not accepted and neglected. These ways are listed as isolating themselves from a group, seeking the attention of others, trying to be obedient by pleasing everyone or trying to look like everyone else."*

**(Cross et al., 2019)**

A Cross-Cultural Study of the Social Experience of Giftedness

*"The phenomenon of social coping among students with gifts and talents (SWGT) is not well understood. In interviews with elementary-, middle-, and high-school aged SWGT (N = 90; 50% female) from the United States, United Kingdom, South Korea, Ireland, and France, the universality of awareness of visibility of their exceptional abilities, high expectations and pressure to achieve from adults and peers, and peer jealousy and rejection, was confirmed. In all countries, SWGT were concerned about peers' upward social comparison and the effects of their outperformance on peers' feelings. SWGT attempted to hide their abilities or conform to peers' behaviors. Prosocial helping behaviors were found among SWGT in nearly all age groups and a focus on the self was a useful coping strategy to students in all countries except France. Parallels are drawn between these findings and stigma theory."*

## Swiatek and Cross social coping measurement: SCQ and validated coping inventories

*The main gifted-specific measure in this literature is Swiatek's Social Coping Questionnaire, developed to capture how gifted students handle the social risks of being seen as gifted. Across studies, its factor structure shifts somewhat, but a stable core keeps reappearing: denying giftedness, trying to fit in or gain acceptance, and using social interaction-related strategies. (1 source)*

A key step in this literature was moving from broad theory to an actual gifted-specific measure. Swiatek developed the **Social Coping Questionnaire (SCQ)** in 1995 to assess "beliefs and activities relating to various social aspects of intellectual giftedness," originally in a 35-item form and later commonly in a 34-item form. The purpose of the SCQ was not just to measure general stress coping, but to capture the specific ways gifted students respond to the stereotypes, pressures, and social risks attached to being recognized as gifted in school. (KONIK, 2023)

The SCQ is especially useful for this topic because it operationalizes the coping patterns discussed in the stigma literature into concrete, repeatable scales. Early analyses identified four factors—**Denial of Giftedness, Popularity/Conformity, Peer Acceptance, and Activity Level**—while later replications produced closely related but somewhat expanded solutions. In one later structure, the questionnaire yielded five factors accounting for 42.0% of the variance: **Denying Giftedness, Social Interaction, Humor, Focus on Popularity/Conformity, and Peer Acceptance**. Across studies, researchers have reported between four and seven factors, but three scales appear most consistently: **denying giftedness, peer acceptance, and social interaction**. (KONIK, 2023)

That pattern matters methodologically. It suggests that social coping in gifted students is **measurable but somewhat context-sensitive**: the same broad coping domain shows up repeatedly, yet the exact grouping of items can vary by sample and study. In other words, the SCQ does not point to one fixed universal profile so much as a recurring family of strategies that are organized a little differently across settings. (KONIK, 2023)

The item content also helps clarify what these scales actually mean. The **denying giftedness** subscale uses direct self-disavowal items such as "I don't think that I am gifted" and "People think that I am gifted, but they are mistaken." The **social interaction** subscale includes prosocial-usefulness items such as helping with homework or explaining course material to classmates. **Humor** captures joking and making others laugh. **Popularity/conformity** taps concern with whether giftedness hurts social fit, and **peer acceptance** includes active blending-in behaviors such as trying to look or act like other students. This item-level detail is important because it shows that validated measurement in this area covers both **label management** and **behavioral strategies for fitting in**. (KONIK, 2023)

This also helps answer the user's question about validated inventories. In the giftedness literature summarized here, the SCQ is the clearest **gifted-specific validated coping inventory** for social coping and identity management, because it was built to measure precisely these stigma-linked strategies rather than general coping alone. It has been used to quantify strategies ranging from denial and conformity to humor, helping others, and socially active participation, and it sits at the center of the Swiatek-Cross measurement tradition. (KONIK, 2023)

### Evidence

**(KONIK, 2023)**

Turkish adaptation of Social Coping Questionnaire for gifted students

> *"These studies claim that gifted children try to cope with their "differentness" by underachieving (Janos et al., 1987), missing to respond to questions in class, asking questions that are not appropriate, acting like the class clown, reducing their vocabulary and lying about getting good grades, making up examinations or assignments to seem tough (Cross et al., 1995), and even denying that they are gifted (Buescher, 1985).Some gifted students believe that they are treated differently and seen as different when others notice their giftedness.(Coleman et al., 2014). Cross et al., 1993;(Manaster et al., 1994)(Manor-Bullock et al., 1995).As a result, these children don't necessarily want to be treated differently or differ intellectually from their peers (Swiatek, 2002)"*
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## Contextual moderators and implications for support, affiliation, and stigma reduction

*Social coping is not fixed. The strategies gifted students use depend a lot on context, especially school climate, peer culture, gender, and national culture, which means support should focus on making high ability feel safer and more socially normal. (2 sources)*

A key takeaway from this literature is that social coping should not be treated as a stable personal trait of "the gifted child." Researchers instead describe it as context-sensitive: the same student may hide ability in one setting and show it more openly in another, because strategy use varies by gender, social context, school environment, and culture. Tourreix et al. summarize this clearly, noting that gifted-specific coping strategies differ "depending on gender, social contexts, and especially the school environment," and that culture shapes which strategies are preferred; for example, hiding/conformity is reported as common in the United States and some European countries, while in South Korea it is more socially valued to show one's abilities (Tourreix

et al., 2023). This matters because it shifts the practical question from “Why is this student coping this way?” to “What in this environment is making visibility of giftedness feel costly?”

That contextual view also points to a straightforward support implication: if stigma and isolation drive coping, then interventions should increase safe affiliation and reduce the social cost of being visibly able. Group counseling tailored to gifted youth is one concrete approach, because it can help students deal with social challenges linked to giftedness and asynchronous development while also teaching friendship and social skills in either group or individual formats (Kennedy et al., 2018). Kennedy et al. also stress that groups including other gifted students can be especially useful for students who are used to feeling different from classmates in ability, interests, or accomplishment, and such groups may help them build social networks with similar peers (Kennedy et al., 2018). In practice, this suggests that affiliation is not just a nice extra: access to true peers can reduce the need for concealment, conformity, or defensive humor by making gifted identity less socially risky in the first place.

The same logic supports broader stigma-reduction work at school level. If students are using denial, minimization, or underperformance partly because high ability carries social penalties, then educators should not read those behaviors only as motivation problems; they may also be signs of a poor person-environment fit. The literature therefore implies that schools should work on peer norms, provide contact with similar-ability students, and create climates where visible effort and high performance do not automatically threaten belonging (Tourreix et al., 2023) (Kennedy et al., 2018). Put simply, the goal is not to force gifted students to “cope better” in unchanged settings, but to make settings where they need less concealment to stay accepted.

## Evidence

**(Tourreix et al., 2023)**

Non-Cognitive Specificities of Intellectually Gifted Children and Adolescents: A Systematic Review of the Literature

> *"One line of research into the social abilities of gifted youth was interested in social coping, and the literature identified evidence of adaptive social coping abilities in intellectually gifted children and adolescents (Lehman and Erdwins 1981). There appear to be coping strategies that are specific to giftedness (Swiatek, 1995)(Swiatek, 2001), such as denying giftedness; reducing the impact of giftedness on peer acceptance; hiding giftedness or conforming to peers' behaviors; denying importance of popularity; using humor; helping others; and engaging in social interactions and a high activity level to keep busy and share common interests. These social coping strategies may vary depending on gender, social contexts, and especially the school environment. Culture also seems to have an impact on the preferential use of certain social coping strategies over others in the case of giftedness (see (Cross et al., 2009). For example, hiding conformity is a social coping strategy widely used by gifted students in the United States and some European countries, whereas this is not the case in South Korea where it is socially valued to show the extent of one's abilities."*

**(Kennedy et al., 2018)**

Counseling Gifted Students: School-Based Considerations and Strategies

> *"Group counseling interventions, tailored to the needs of gifted youth, can help students cope with social challenges associated with giftedness and/or asynchronous development, and there are many available social skills and friendship skills curricula that may be appropriate for use with gifted students in individual or group settings (Fisher & Kennedy, 2016;(Reis et al., 2004).Counseling groups that include other gifted students can be a unique experience for gifted students who are used to being different from their classmates when it comes to abilities, accomplishments, or interests (Peterson, 2014).Such interventions could help students to build social networks by introducing other students with similar abilities or differences."*